ERA 11

The End of Reconstruction

1865 – 1877

Sharecropping · the KKK · the Compromise of 1877

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

Why did Reconstruction fail to secure lasting equality for freedpeople?

KEY TERMS

Sharecropping · the Ku Klux Klan · Redeemer governments · the Compromise of 1877

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 5.11 · AMSCO Ch. 5.11

FREEDOM WITHOUT LAND

The Economic Question

'40 Acres and a Mule'?

HOPE

Land for the Freed

Freedpeople expected land to build independent lives.

→

PROMISE

Sherman's Land

40,000 settle on confiscated coastal land.

→

REVERSAL

Land Returned

Johnson restores the land to former owners.

→

RESULT

Landless

Most freedpeople are left with no land of their own.

The Sharecropping Trap

NO LAND

Work Another's Land

Landless families farm a planter's land for a share of the crop.

→

ON CREDIT

Debt to the Store

They buy seed and supplies on credit at high interest.

→

THE TRAP

Endless Debt

Debt exceeds their share—binding them to the land year after year.

SECTION

Southern Backlash

The Ku Klux Klan



- The **Ku Klux Klan**, founded in 1866, used terror to restore white supremacy.
- Klansmen beat, lynched, and murdered Black citizens and their allies—especially at election time.
- Congress struck back with the **Force Acts**, but violence persisted.

SECTION

Reconstruction Collapses

Why Reconstruction Ended

I

Northern Fatigue

War memories faded and the North lost the will to enforce it.

II

'Redeemer' Governments

White conservative Democrats retook Southern statehouses.

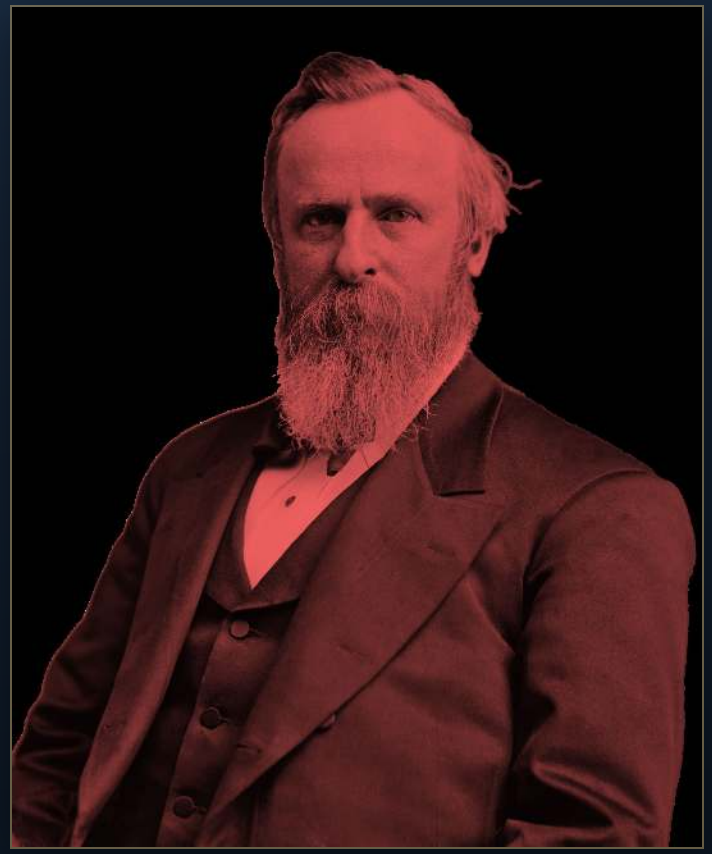
III

Terror & the Courts

Klan violence and hostile Supreme Court rulings gutted Black rights.

The Compromise of 1877

- The disputed 1876 election was settled by a backroom deal.
- Republican **Rutherford B. Hayes** became president.
- In return, federal troops left the South—ending **Reconstruction**.



The Long Shadow

I

Segregation

Jim Crow laws would soon enforce racial separation.

II

Disenfranchisement

Black Southerners were stripped of the vote for generations.

III

An Unfinished Revolution

The promise of equal citizenship went unfulfilled for a century.

The Court Retreats

COURT CASE

Slaughterhouse Cases (1873)

The Supreme Court read the 14th Amendment's "privileges or immunities" clause narrowly. It protected only a short list of national rights and left most civil rights to the states.

COURT CASE

United States v. Cruikshank (1876)

After the Colfax Massacre (1873), the Court ruled that the 14th Amendment limits only state action, not private individuals. Federal prosecutions of the white attackers failed, weakening federal protection of Black citizens.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The End of Reconstruction

1. Without land, most freedpeople fell into **sharecropping** and debt.
2. White **terror (the KKK)** and 'Redeemer' governments rolled back Black political power.
3. The **Compromise of 1877** withdrew federal troops and ended Reconstruction—opening the door to **Jim Crow segregation**.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The End of Reconstruction

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **sharecropping** trapped freedpeople in a cycle of poverty and debt.

ARGUMENTATION

Did Reconstruction **fail**, or was it a partial success later undone? Make and defend a claim.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did the **end of Reconstruction** shape race relations in the South for the next century?

Up next — **Lesson 28: The Gilded Age** (industry, big business & monopoly)